

By and through

Learner workbook

Explain a method or a process without changing the meaning.

Understand the distinction

By often introduces how something is done: by checking the map, by train, by email.

Through can present a route, a channel, or a process: through the park, through an agency, through regular practice.

By + -ing and through + noun are useful starting patterns, not a complete rule. Both words have other uses. Both can introduce a method in some contexts: by working together / through working together. By highlights how; through can highlight the process.

Compare the patterns

METHOD

I saved time by booking online.

Booking is the action that helped.

PROCESS

She gained confidence through practice.

Practice is the process behind the change.

ROUTE

We walked through the station.

Through describes movement from one part to another.

Read each example and notice how its form changes the meaning. Use these distinctions to choose your answers on the following pages.

Check your understanding

Circle one answer for each question. There is one correct choice among the options shown. Check the answer key after choosing.

1. Complete with an -ing form: I checked the time by ___ at my phone.

- A. look
- B. looked
- C. looking

2. We found our apartment through an agency. How did the agency help?

- A. The agency connected us with the apartment or its owner.
- B. The agency tells us how long the search lasted.
- C. The agency was the route we physically walked through.

3. Is by always followed by an -ing verb? Choose the statement with a valid example.

- A. No. By can only be followed by a person.
- B. Yes. Every use of by must have an -ing verb.
- C. No: by train, by email, or by Friday.

Choose the best response

Choose the response that fits the situation. Check both its meaning and its grammar.

4. Which pair correctly describes a learning method and a process that builds confidence?

- A. I learn phrases by writing examples. I gain confidence through regular conversations.
- B. I learn phrases by writing examples. I gain confidence through to converse.
- C. I learn phrases by write examples. I gain confidence through regular conversations.

Review your choices

Use the answer explanations on the next page. If you chose a different answer, find the detail that makes it unsuitable and try the question again.

Practice online

The web lesson gives feedback for the option you select and lets you try again. No written response is required.

Answers and explanation

1. C. looking

By looking explains the method.

2. A. The agency connected us with the apartment or its owner.

Through identifies the intermediary: someone or an organization that helps connect two sides.

3. C. No: by train, by email, or by Friday.

The form depends on the meaning and phrase.

4. A. I learn phrases by writing examples. I gain confidence through regular conversations.

By writing describes the method; through conversations identifies a helpful process.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-05.html